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Course Content

Understanding Plagiarism

Definition of Plagiarism

The Cambridge dictionary defines plagiarism as **"*the process or practice using another person's ideas or work and pretending that it is your own*"**. In other words, it means taking other people's intellectual property and using it in one's own work without acknowledging the original source of the information or ideas. Plagiarism also amounts to *"Academic Dishonesty"* which can lead to strict academic and legal repercussions.

Reasons for plagiarism

Provided below are some of the probable reasons for which one might plagiarise:

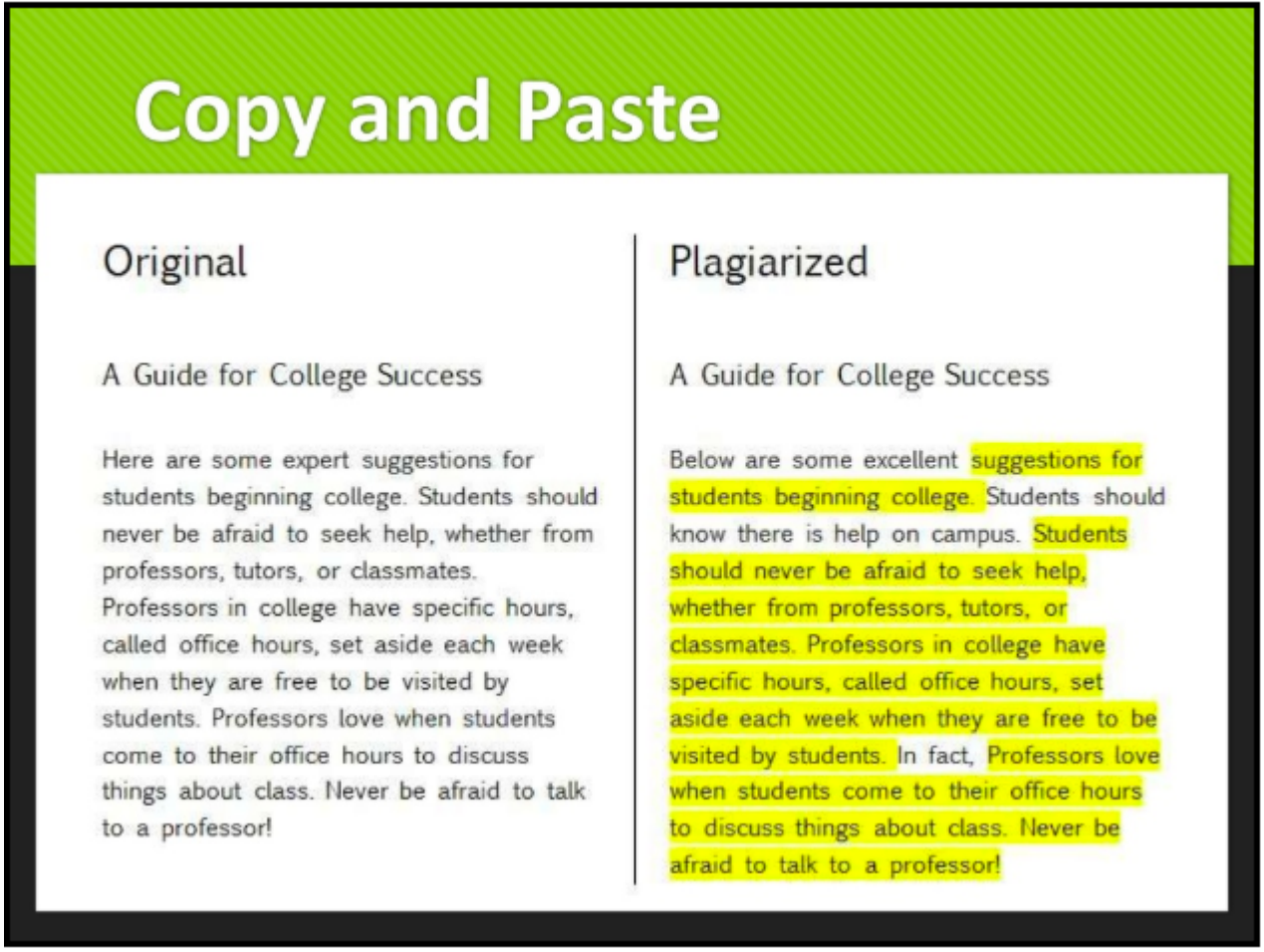
- A learner might not be aware of what plagiarism means.
- A learner might not be exposed to the conventions of academic writing.
- A learner might resort to plagiarism in a panic because of an approaching deadline. German research has found it to be the most common factor for plagiarism.
- A learner might want to prevent themselves from failure and hence sees copying as an easy way out to ensure success.
- It can be a response to information overload and the ease with which text can be cut and pasted from other electronic documents or pages on the internet.
- It can be an attempt not to displease a tutor.
- The student may copy out text word for word during note-taking and then forget to paraphrase the text for the assignment.
- A learner might not be aware of how to paraphrase properly.
- A learner may deliberately plagiarise to gain credit.

Forms of Plagiarism explained

I. Copying from a single source or Copy-Paste

Many times we come across books that have explained ideas in detail and are very similar to what we had set to write. In that case, learners are likely to simply copy and paste from the source. It entails copying large chunks of text to fill in their own sentences.

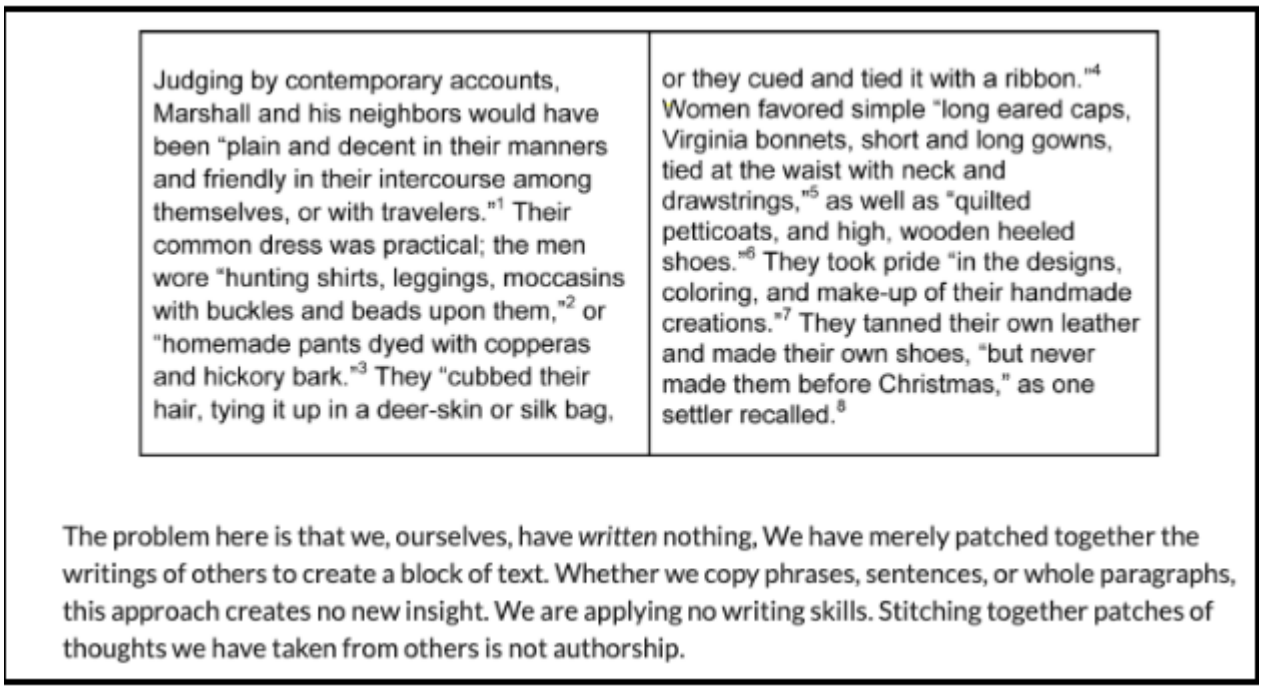
For Example:



II. Patchwork Plagiarism

It is similar to copy-paste plagiarism, only in this, the learner forms their statements and paragraphs from multiple sources without citing them, weaves them as one paragraph(s) and presents as their own.

For Example:



III. Paraphrasing

"Properly executed, paraphrasing means restating an idea in a simpler and shorter way. It does not mean changing a word or two in someone else's sentence. It does not mean changing the sentence structure while maintaining the original words. It does not

mean changing a few words to synonyms. All of this is plagiarism, not paraphrasing." (Elizabeth Shown Mills, QuickLesson 15: Plagiarism—Five "Copywrongs" of Historical Writing)

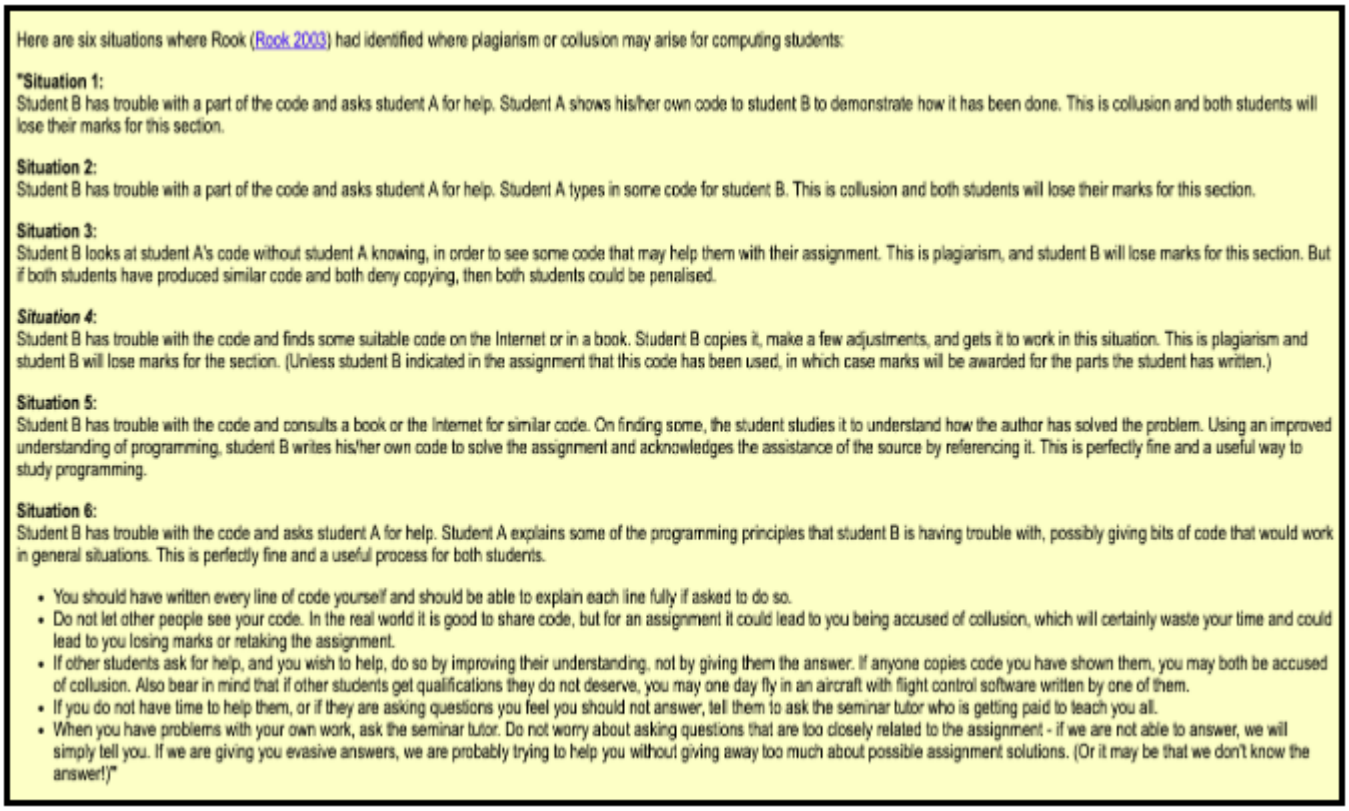
For Example:

Morison: 1959[5]	**Mackay: 1998–99**[6]
"During his career he visited some of the most beautiful parts of the world—Cape Breton, the Windward Islands, Jamaica, Galicia, Brittany, the Hebrides, the Baltic and the Black Sea; yet not once in his voluminous correspondence does he indicate any appreciation of them; and in only one letter, about the great gale of October 1780, does he mention the majesty of the sea."	"In the course of his career, he visited some of the most beautiful parts of the world—the Caribbean islands, Nova Scotia, Galicia, the Baltic, and the Black Sea as well as the eastern seaboard of America and the coasts of Britain—yet nowhere in his vast correspondence does he betray any appreciation of them. In only one letter, written in October 1780 in the aftermath of a great storm, does he allude to the majesty of the sea."

IV. Collusion

Simply put, It means representing a group work as one's own. See the image below for a detailed description.

For Example:



Here are six situations where Rook (Rook 2003) had identified where plagiarism or collusion may arise for computing students:

"Situation 1:
Student B has trouble with a part of the code and asks student A for help. Student A shows his/her own code to student B to demonstrate how it has been done. This is collusion and both students will lose their marks for this section.

Situation 2:
Student B has trouble with a part of the code and asks student A for help. Student A types in some code for student B. This is collusion and both students will lose their marks for this section.

Situation 3:
Student B looks at student A's code without student A knowing, in order to see some code that may help them with their assignment. This is plagiarism, and student B will lose marks for this section. But if both students have produced similar code and both deny copying, then both students could be penalised.

Situation 4:
Student B has trouble with the code and finds some suitable code on the Internet or in a book. Student B copies it, make a few adjustments, and gets it to work in this situation. This is plagiarism and student B will lose marks for the section. (Unless student B indicated in the assignment that this code has been used, in which case marks will be awarded for the parts the student has written.)

Situation 5:
Student B has trouble with the code and consults a book or the Internet for similar code. On finding some, the student studies it to understand how the author has solved the problem. Using an improved understanding of programming, student B writes his/her own code to solve the assignment and acknowledges the assistance of the source by referencing it. This is perfectly fine and a useful way to study programming.

Situation 6:
Student B has trouble with the code and asks student A for help. Student A explains some of the programming principles that student B is having trouble with, possibly giving bits of code that would work in general situations. This is perfectly fine and a useful process for both students.

- You should have written every line of code yourself and should be able to explain each line fully if asked to do so.
- Do not let other people see your code. In the real world it is good to share code, but for an assignment it could lead to you being accused of collusion, which will certainly waste your time and could lead to you losing marks or retaking the assignment.
- If other students ask for help, and you wish to help, do so by improving their understanding, not by giving them the answer. If anyone copies code you have shown them, you may both be accused of collusion. Also bear in mind that if other students get qualifications they do not deserve, you may one day fly in an aircraft with flight control software written by one of them.
- If you do not have time to help them, or if they are asking questions you feel you should not answer, tell them to ask the seminar tutor who is getting paid to teach you all.
- When you have problems with your own work, ask the seminar tutor. Do not worry about asking questions that are too closely related to the assignment - if we are not able to answer, we will simply tell you. If we are giving you evasive answers, we are probably trying to help you without giving away too much about possible assignment solutions. (Or it may be that we don't know the answer!)"

V. Buying Papers Online

As the name suggests, this comes under the most blatant form of plagiarism where a learner resorts to buying pre-written work to be submitted as their own.

To summarise, plagiarism can be understood as conscious and subconscious. Here the former is where the learner is aware of their act of cheating and decides to go ahead with it nonetheless, whereas on the other hand, the learner may plagiarize because

they are not aware of what does plagiarism means and what actions amount to it.

Common Misconceptions around Plagiarism

- *If someone is copying from their own work it doesn't categorize as plagiarism.*
  - Any work, even if done by the same person previously for which credit has been accorded cannot be used in a different document without citing the original work.
- *If the ideas and information came from a basic textbook, they do not require referencing*.
  - All sources of information should be acknowledged unless it is common knowledge. For example, the statement: *Delhi is the capital of India* needs not be cited because it is common knowledge.
- *If there is a bibliography or reference list given towards the end, there is no need to put citations in the body of the text.*
  - It is not enough to just have one final list of resources. It has to be clearly cited within the body of the text too if the idea has come from another source and put in quotation marks if it has been copied word for word. In addition to this, the reference list should be provided towards the end.
- *If the original sources put it better than anybody else could so it is okay to copy.*
  - No, you are expected to use the sources constructively, demonstrate that you have understood them, and have been able to use them effectively in the assignment. You need to use the sources in a way that demonstrates your understanding of the texts.
- *You can copy from several sources as long as you have quotation marks and a reference list.*
  - No, you are encouraged to use a variety of sources but you should not be copying extensively or directly from them. You should try and limit the use of quotations so that your essay does not become a 'patchwork' of other people's words or ideas. Any direct quotations you do decide to use should be within quotation marks and referenced correctly.
- *Just changing everything into your own words is enough.*
  - If all you have done is summarised someone else's ideas then you have still copied because you have made it appear as if the ideas, arrangement of material, etc. were your own.
- *It is OK to paraphrase everything as long as all sources are cited in the reference list.*
  - Even when you paraphrase somebody else's work, it still needs to be acknowledged within the assignment. To simply summarise the work of others and not acknowledge this within the text (even if the works are in the reference list) is still trying to pass someone else's work off as your own.

Guidelines

So far we have abundantly elaborated on what constitutes plagiarism and the implications it has on a learner. In this section, we are going to share some examples of how a well-cited assignment looks like. In academic writing, there are two prima facie rules,

If the text is paraphrased then the author and the year of publication should be mentioned, along with the detailed bibliography or reference list in the end.

If exact words are being copied then they should be marked in double-quotes.

At Great Learning, there are different assessments that a learner has to take. While submitting an assessment, we expect you to provide the online/offline sources that you have used to complete the assessment and their relevant links. It should also have a detailed reference list at the end of the assessment.

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